UNIT 17

Effects of British Rule



Learning Objectives

To acquaint oneself with the knowledge of

- British East India Company's emergence as a territorial power
- Failure of dual government established by Robert Clive and assumption of direct responsibility of the Company under Regulating Act of 1773
- Cornwallis' Permanent Settlement in Bengal and Thomas Munro's Ryotwari System in Madras Presidency
- Wellesley's Subsidiary Alliance and Dalhousie's Doctrine of Lapse leading to annexation of more number of Indian territories without war
- The Company government's relationship with Indian Rulers
- Reforms in civil and judicial administration carried out by Cornwallis and Wellesley
- Social and educational reforms and the building of rail and communication networks attempted by Bentinck and Dalhousie
- Neglect of irrigation and exploitation of forest resources by the colonial state leading to frequent famines, forcing the peasants and artisans to move out of the country as indentured labourers
- Drain of Wealth theory of Dadabhai Naoroji

Introduction

The general breakdown of the central authority, in the wake of Mughal's fall, resulted in a English trading company taking over India. Initially, the English East India Company's focus was not on administration. Its aim was ensuring smooth trade. However, after the terrible Bengal famine of 1770, they began to exercise power with some responsibility. Not withstanding their exploitative economic policy, their professed objective was the safety of the people they governed and administration of justice. The justification for their expansionist policy was the extermination of tyranny of the local rulers and the harassment by robbers and marauders in the country. Railways and telegraph, introduced for easier communication, also served the purpose of curbing resistance and the control of the local population. However, their agrarian and commercial policies had a ruinous impact on the economy. India's wealth was drained in several forms. By the 1830s there was large scale emigration of ruined peasants and weavers to plantations in the British Empire countries.

17.1 Establishment of British Raj

Buxar was the real foundation battle for British dominion in India. Not only the Nawab of Bengal and Oudh, but the Mughal emperor ShahAlam II and his prime minister were also

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